

Effective Scheduling Guide

How to synchronize global time zones, manage unexpected events with empathy, and maintain absolute respect for your conversation partner's time.

Connecting people from different hubs around the world is an incredible experience, but it comes with a technical and human challenge: **time management**. On the **Language Exchange** platform, respecting each other's schedules is the first step toward building a relationship of trust. This guide gathers our rules and recommendations for handling time zones, delays, and unforeseen events with professionalism and transparency.

1. Unraveling the Mystery of Time Zones

Our platform always tries to automatically adjust times based on your current location. However, when arranging details directly with your partner or sending calendar invites, keep these best practices in mind:

- **Explicitly confirm the time zone acronym:** When sending a message, use clear terms. Instead of just saying "see you at 2 PM", prefer: "See you at 2 PM Brasília time (BRT/UTC-3), which is equivalent to 6 PM in your London time zone (BST/UTC+1)".
- **Pay attention to Daylight Saving Time (DST):** Countries in the Northern Hemisphere change their clocks at different times than ours. Free online tools like **World Time Buddy** or **Time and Date** are excellent allies for checking exact conversions before finalizing a commitment.

2. Rescheduling and Cancellation Policies

Unforeseen work, health, or academic events happen to everyone. The difference lies in how you communicate the situation. We have established strict guidelines to protect our volunteers' time:

24-Hour Advance Notice Rule

Need to change the day or time? Do so at least **24 hours in advance** directly through the platform. This gives your partner enough time to reorganize their study routine or free up the slot for someone else.

Last-Minute Cancellations

If a medical or technical emergency occurs with **less than 24 hours** before the meeting, send a message immediately explaining yourself with clarity and kindness. Disappearing without notice breaks community trust.

No-Show Policy (Absences Without Notice)

Failing to attend a scheduled session without any prior notice is considered a **serious infraction** in our network. Users with recurring unexcused absences will have their profiles suspended from the platform's automatic scheduling system.

3. Guidelines for Handling Delays

Traffic backed up, previous meeting ran over, or internet dropped? Here is the expected conduct protocol in the community:

If YOU are running late:

- Notify as soon as you realize the issue. Send a short message: *"Hello! I had a small unexpected issue delivering a project, but I will only be 5 minutes late. Can you wait for me?"*.
- Upon joining the call, apologize briefly and remember: your delay should not penalize the other person's time. If the session was set for 40 minutes and you were 10 minutes late, the session will last 30 minutes, unless your partner explicitly offers to extend the time.

If YOUR PARTNER is running late:

- **The 15-Minute Tolerance Rule:** Wait in the meeting room for up to 15 minutes. While waiting, send a polite message reminding them of the session.
- If after 15 minutes the person does not show up and does not respond, you are fully authorized to close the link. Go to the corresponding tab to record the session status.

4. Ready-to-Use Message Templates (Copy & Paste Scripts)

Unsure how to write politely and directly during delicate moments? Use these structured examples:

✓ Script for Rescheduling in Advance

"Hello, [Partner's Name]! How are you? Just dropping a line to let you know that an urgent professional commitment came up at the time we reserved for our language exchange. Can we reschedule our meeting to [Date] or [Date] on the website? I apologize for the inconvenience and greatly appreciate your understanding!"

✓ Script for Last-Minute Emergency

"Hello, [Partner's Name]! I sincerely apologize, but a force majeure event just came up right now and I won't be able to connect on time for today's session. I know your time is precious and I am very sorry for the short notice. As soon as things normalize here, I will reach out so we can reschedule, okay?"

Managing your time well is one of the most valued soft skills globally.
Take care of your schedule on the **Language Exchange** platform!